> to 'the exposition of ideas,' *Winters* v. *New York,* 333 U. S. 507, 510 (1948), 'there is practically universal agreement that a major purpose of th[e] Amendment was to protect the free discussion of governmental affairs . . . .' *Mills* v. *Alabama,* 384 U. S. 214, 218 (1966)." *Buckley,* 424 U. S., at 14.

As the public-sector agency shop unquestionably impinges upon the interests protected by the First Amendment, I turn to the justifications offered for it by the Detroit Board of Education.[13]

B

"Neither the right to associate nor the right to participate in political activities is absolute . . . ." *CSC* v. *Letter Carriers,* 413 U. S. 548, 567 (1973). This is particularly true in the field of public employment, where "the State has interests as an employer in regulating the speech of its employees that differ significantly from those it possesses in connection with regulation of the speech of the citizenry in general." *Pickering* v. *Board of Education,* 391 U. S. 563, 568 (1968). Nevertheless, even in public employment, "a significant impairment of First Amendment rights must survive exacting scrutiny." *Elrod* v. *Burns,* 427 U. S., at 362 (plurality opinion); accord, *id.,* at 381 (POWELL, J., dissenting).

> "The [governmental] interest advanced must be paramount, one of vital importance, and the burden is on the

[13] Compelled support of a private association is fundamentally different from compelled support of government. Clearly, a local school board does not need to demonstrate a compelling state interest every time it spends a taxpayer's money in ways the taxpayer finds abhorrent. But the reason for permitting the government to compel the payment of taxes and to spend money on controversial projects is that the government is representative of the people. The same cannot be said of a union, which is representative only of one segment of the population, with certain common interests. The withholding of financial support is fully protected as speech in this context.